

IOWA STATE UNIVERSITY
Department of Agricultural Education and Studies

Program Handbook

for Agricultural Education
Graduate Program

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www.ageds.iastate.edu

Table of Contents

INTRODUCTION	3
CREDIT LOAD AND LEVEL.....	3
Course load	3
Levels.....	4
When are Courses Offered?.....	4
COMMITTEE AND ACADEMIC PLAN	4
Masters non-thesis	5
Masters thesis	6
Doctoral.....	7
AGEDS 6150 (1 credit) Doctoral Seminars.....	8
AGEDS 6170 (1-6 credits) Internship	8
Masters/Doctoral (MS/PhD)	9
Agricultural Extension Education Program Focus (Specialization).....	9
Certificate in Education and Outreach.....	10
Additional Academic Plan Notes	10
Change from Graduate Academic Advisor to Major Professor.....	10
When Comments are Required on the Academic Plan.....	10
What aspects of the Academic Plan require exceptions?.....	11
Older transfer courses/older ISU courses.....	11
5990 and 6990	11
Writing a Creative Component, Thesis or Dissertation	12
COMPLETING YOUR PROGRAM.....	12
Final Oral Exam.....	12
Formatting	13
Frequently Asked Questions	13

INTRODUCTION

This Program Handbook provides policies and procedures specific to the graduate program of agricultural education, and its degree program, program focus, and graduate certificate. The Handbook provides information to students who have already started or enrolled but is not a guide to admissions. Students, faculty, staff, and those external to the department should consult this document, as well as review the policies and resources listed on the Graduate College website, especially the [Graduate College Handbook](#). This Handbook alone is not enough to assist students to succeed with graduate education; it also relies on information in the Iowa State University Courses and Programs (the Course Catalog). [Find events and deadlines for graduate students here](#). The Handbook is meant to be compact and address the most common questions asked.

Major changes to the Handbook, such as policies and procedures, will be made by majority vote of the AGEDS Graduate Admissions and Recruitment Committee. Minor changes to this document will be made by the administrative staff and DOGE without a vote from the Committee. The DOGE will distinguish between them.

Contacts for information shared in this handbook include [Dr. Nancy Grudens-Schuck](#), Director of Graduate Education (DOGE) and Director of Certificates (DOC); [Dr. Michael Retallick](#), Department Chair; [Dr. Scott Smalley](#), AGEDS Teacher Education Coordinator; [Paige Zhorne](#) and [Suzanne Showalter](#), Graduate Student Support.

CREDIT LOAD AND LEVEL

COURSE LOAD

Almost all graduate students can and should take fewer courses than undergrads. This guidance can surprise new graduate students and new graduate advisors. The reason is because graduate courses can require more reading, reading that is more difficult, more independent research, group and project work that is more complicated, field work, and other unexpected activities. Graduate students should use non-course time to write proposals, create research or creative component products, attend and present at conferences and seminars, meet with different faculty, and develop professionally in a graduate-level capacity.

A student may enroll in an undergraduate course as part of their course load. However, this decision may or may not decrease the course load difficulty of a specific term. The major professor can advise on course load and access forms for an exception.

According to [the Graduate Handbook 2.1.1](#) “During the academic year, graduate students not on assistantship must be registered for a minimum of nine credits to be considered full-time students or five credits to be considered half-time students. Students on an assistantship appointment during the academic year are considered full-time.”

For example:

- Students who are taking their program by distance and working professionally are recommended to take fewer credits.

- Full-time employees of ISU are restricted to six credits. In some cases, student employees are allowed to take more.

There is a [Grad Handbook policy for limits of course load](#).

LEVELS

Graduate students take 5000 and 6000 level courses for most of their program. These are considered graduate-level courses at Iowa State. Lower levels are considered undergraduate and are limited in the number allowable on the Academic Plan. However, undergrad courses may be allowed on graduate student Academic Plan, in the agricultural education program focus. Here are examples:

- Students enrolled for teacher certification are required to fulfill several state-level requirements. These can sometimes be filled only by courses in lower-level designations, such as 3000 or 4000. The Teacher Education Coordinator, [Dr. Scott Smalley](#), is the best source of up-to-date information on substitutions and courses.
- Some methods courses (i.e., statistics) are lower-level, and some students are urged to take lower-level courses by their committee to enhance their research or professional advancement. Some may be approved because required courses at the 5000 and 6000-level were cancelled. There is also some free choice, especially of a limited number of 4000-level.
- A doctoral student may take a lower-level course to catch up on subject matter for their research, but the course may not be permitted on the Academic Plan. However, the course will be listed on the transcript and count in the GPA. The advisor and student should work together on this.

WHEN ARE COURSES OFFERED?

In the agricultural education program of study, and in other graduate programs of study, courses typically are not offered every semester. This is normal and requires planning. Some, but not many, are offered in the summer. Students and advisers should work together to identify required courses that should be taken at first opportunity. If a student takes an Incomplete, or a Retake is needed for a course that earned an F, the course-offering pattern can delay a program. Students and faculty who are accustomed to every-term course offerings will not find this to be the case in graduate study.

COMMITTEE AND ACADEMIC PLAN

The Committee and Academic Plan forms generate the most questions from both students and faculty. It is partly a people-process and a digital process. The Committee is the decision maker of the Academic Plan. Steps must be completed in this order: Complete the Committee form in WorkDay ([here is how-to Knowledge Based Article \(KBA\)](#)). The form will circulate to your committee members, the DOGE and the Graduate College for approval. For more information on who should be on a committee, see below. Faculty serving on the Committee will be required to review and approve their addition to the Committee. [This KBA explains how faculty review and approve their membership](#).

After approval from the Graduate College, the student then completes the Academic Plan ([here is a how-to KBA](#)). The Academic Plan is ONLY the courses the student will take to earn their degree.

The process for deciding who does what on the forms varies by degree program. Masters non-thesis, masters thesis, and doctoral share some procedures, but differ in some respects.

MASTERS NON-THESIS

All non-thesis students complete a creative component, but teacher education students frequently refer to it as a teacher portfolio.

Create a Committee: As decided by policy of the Department of Agricultural Education and Studies for the non-thesis degree, students need to select three committee members:

- 1) A major professor
 - a. The Graduate Academic Advisor, who was serving in a temporary capacity, is usually selected by the student as the major professor.
- 2) An agricultural education member
 - a. The student should not formally invite the agricultural education committee member to serve until they talk with the major professor
- 3) An outside member
 - a. The student should not formally invite the outside committee member to serve until they talk with the major professor
 - b. “The outside graduate faculty member(s) of the Academic Plan Committee (APC) provide relevant specialized knowledge or a different perspective helpful to the planning, execution, and reporting of research, or some aspect of intellectual diversity deemed important by the committee and/or major.” ([Section 6.2.3 of the Graduate Handbook](#)).
 - c. In instances decided by the student and major professor together, a graduate faculty member of agricultural education may fulfil the outside role.
- 4) If a student has an unusual situation, such as if a committee member is an affiliate, please state so in the comment area.

The student must get the permission of all three members to serve on the committee by an in-person conversation or via email.

Meeting: Students and faculty are not required to hold a meeting of the committee prior to the submission of the Academic Plan. The Plan can be submitted at any time, including the first term. Communication is needed among student and all committee members before submission of the Plan, so that approval goes smoothly.

The Committee must approve any minors or transfer courses, and the designation of a program focus (formerly option or area of specialization). Any graduate transfer courses that are listed on the student’s Academic Plan must have a transcript attached. Comments must be written on the actual Academic Plan to explain courses that substitute for required AGEDS courses, or for which the function is not clear or which exceed the limits on lower-level courses. AGEDS 5900s,

which are independent studies, or substitutions should be explained in the comment area with 5-8 words about the topic.

- All courses must be approved for use on the Academic Plan to meet the course requirements.
- Graduate transfer courses that are listed must have a transcript uploaded and attached, even though Admissions has a copy.
- Committee must approve use of substitutions for required courses as electives, or as expired, which requires a separate process. This is to allow committee members, the DOGE, and the Graduate College to have easy access to the linked transcript.
- Expired Courses: Expired courses are defined in [Ch. 6.3.4 of the Graduate College Handbook](#). Refer to *Older transfer courses/older ISU courses* below for more detail.
- Notes must be written to explain courses that substitute for required AGEDS courses or are otherwise not clear. The vote of the committee must be indicated.
- 5900s or 5930s should be explained in the comment area.

MASTERS THESIS

Create a Committee

As decided by the Graduate College, thesis students need to select three committee members:

- 1) A major professor
 - a. The Graduate Academic Advisor, who was serving in a temporary capacity, is usually selected by the student as the major professor.
- 2) An agricultural education member
 - a. The student should not formally invite the agricultural education committee member to serve until they talk with the major professor
- 3) An outside member
 - a. The student should not formally invite the outside committee member to serve until they talk with the major professor
 - b. “The outside graduate faculty member(s) of the APC provide relevant specialized knowledge or a different perspective helpful to the planning, execution, and reporting of research, or some aspect of intellectual diversity deemed important by the committee and/or major.” ([Section 6.2.3 of the Graduate Handbook](#)).
 - c. In instances decided by the student and major professor together, a graduate faculty member of agricultural education may fulfil this role but it more common, and considered more in line with intellectual diversity, for thesis students to reach into other departments for academic support.
- 4) If a student has an unusual situation, such as if a committee member is an affiliate, please state so in the comment area.

The student must get the permission of all three members to serve on the Committee by an in-person conversation or via email.

Meeting: Per Department of Agricultural Education and Studies policy, an in-person or virtual meeting of the whole committee is required creating the Plan.

The Committee must approve any minors or transfer courses, and the designation of a program focus. Any graduate transfer courses that are listed on the student's Academic Plan must have a transcript attached. Comments must be written on the actual Academic Plan to explain courses that substitute for required AGEDS courses, or for which the function is not clear or which exceed the limits on lower-level courses. AGEDS 5900s, which are independent studies, should be explained in the comment area with 5-8 words about the topic. Items needed:

- All courses must be approved for use on the Academic Plan to meet the course requirements.
- A version of the research proposal, from 3 pages to 15 pages, with guidance from the graduate academic advisor. Committee must approve. This is not attached to the form.
- Graduate transfer courses that are listed must have a transcript uploaded and attached, even though Admissions has a copy.
- Committee must approve use of substitutions for required courses as electives, or as expired, which requires a separate process. This is to allow committee members, the DOGE, and the Graduate College to have easy access to the linked transcript.
- Expired Courses: Expired courses are defined in [Ch. 6.3.4 of the Graduate College Handbook](#). Refer to *Older transfer courses/older ISU courses* below for more detail.
- Comments must be written to explain courses that substitute for required AGEDS courses or are otherwise not clear. The vote of the Committee must be indicated.
- 5900s or 5930s should be explained in the comment area.

Submission timeline: Typical time for submission of the Academic Plan for a student in the Masters thesis program of study is second semester of year one, or first semester of year two. This is because the thesis research topic must be developed, which likely depends on taking courses first. Also, coaching proposal writing takes time.

DOCTORAL

Create a Committee:

Per the Graduate College, doctoral students need to select five committee members:

- 1) A major professor
 - a. The Graduate Academic Advisor, who was serving in a temporary capacity, is usually selected by the student as the major professor.
- 2) Two additional agricultural education members
 - a. The student should not formally invite the agricultural education committee members to serve until they talk with the major professor
- 3) Two outside members
 - a. The student should not formally invite the outside committee members to serve until they talk with the major professor
 - b. "The outside graduate faculty member(s) of the APC provide relevant specialized knowledge or a different perspective helpful to the planning, execution, and reporting of research, or some aspect of intellectual diversity deemed important by the committee and/or major." ([Section 6.2.3 of the Graduate Handbook](#)).
 - c. The outside committee members are commonly from different departments and often from different colleges.

- 4) If a student has an unusual situation, such as if a committee member is an affiliate, please state so in the comment area.

Meeting: Before the Academic Plan can be submitted, an in-person or virtual meeting of all five committee members is required, and several items need to be approved at the meeting. The major professor has the responsibility to coordinate with the student, and develop materials to a high-quality level, so that all aspects of the first Academic Plan meeting are met prior to submission.

Items needed:

- All courses must be approved for use on the Academic Plan to meet the course requirements.
- A version of the research proposal, likely based on one of the three formats of the Graduate College, from 5 pages to 30 pages for the first Academic Plan Committee meeting. (Guidance/pre-approval from Graduate Academic Advisor but may also be in accordance with minor member conventions for the program focus.) Committee must approve. Do not attach.
- Graduate transfer courses that are listed must have a transcript attached. Committee must approve use of courses as substitutions of required courses, as electives.
- Signed *Meet the Faculty* sheet. Committee must review. Do not attach.
- Expired Courses: Expired courses are defined in [Ch. 6.3.4 of the Graduate College Handbook](#). Refer to *Older transfer courses/older ISU courses* below for more detail.
- Plan for substitution of other courses for required AGEDS courses, such as from other departments. Add comment.
- Experience plan review. The committee must review. Do not attach.
- Academic curriculum vitae review. Committee must review. Do not attach.
- 5900s and 5930s should be explained in the comment area.

Submission timeline: Students may take up to nine months to a year due to scheduling or more likely because the research topic needs time to be developed based on courses which are taken during the first year. This includes research and methods courses. The submission should not be delayed beyond one year due to the scheduling of requirements for the Preliminary Exam.

The [Graduate Resources page on the AGEDS](#) webpage provides many supports and resources for students. It suggests [Doctoral Plan completion after a full year of study](#).

AGEDS 6150 (1 credit) Doctoral Seminars

The doctoral seminars emphasize advanced, in depth, or updated topics and opportunities. They are offered as 1 credit, “pass/no pass” courses. Enrollment in five AGEDS 6150 seminars are required for doctoral students. Masters students are permitted to take the courses. The courses are labeled by topic and taught by AGEDS faculty members. These courses are typically taught once every third semester, so advisors should urge students to enroll when offered.

AGEDS 6170 (1-6 credits) Internship

This doctoral internship is required as part of the doctoral program only. Start with [this document](#) in [AGEDS Graduate Resources](#). Below are examples of past internships experienced by AGEDS

doctoral students. Some provided modest pay, some were set up by the students, some were formal programs through professional associations, and they varied in length from one term to one year. Students continue to work on their doctoral studies, even during their internship.

- Office of Instructional Technology at a community college
- Research Institute for Studies in Education (RISE) evaluation and data management at ISU
- Iowa Department of Natural Resources, Water Quality, evaluation of IOWATER program
- American Evaluation Association, Graduate Education Diversity Internship, EnCompass Inc. monitoring and evaluation
- Western Michigan University Evaluation Center ATE/STEM internship
- Extensive visiting and shadowing of Extension Directors at three county-level offices

MASTERS/DOCTORAL (MS/PHD)

A university-wide option is the MS/PhD program of study. The purpose of this program of study is to encourage high performing, highly focused, and highly prepared masters students to combine a doctoral program with their masters thesis program. Although the result is often a decreased amount of time between the masters and doctoral program, the intention is not fiscal savings or time savings. The product is a focused research project that has been conducted over the span of the MS/PhD. The student should demonstrate that funding is secured for the MS/PhD time period. There should be communication between the masters student and Major Professor if the student desires to be in this program.

Students interested in this program of study must reapply for admission into the PhD program when it comes time for the transition from MS to PhD. The Graduate Admissions and Recruitment Committee will review the student's record for doctoral admissions qualities, as well as their goals and opportunities. The committee must vote to recommend the student for admission. The final approval and decision to admit will come from the Graduate College.

AGRICULTURAL EXTENSION EDUCATION PROGRAM FOCUS (SPECIALIZATION)

This graduate programs longest offered program focus (formerly specialization) is Agricultural Extension Education. A student's creative component, thesis, or dissertation must directly address the extension system in any of its worldwide forms. A student's Academic Plan will indicate the program focus, and it will be listed on the graduate's transcript. For a list of required courses for the program focus, [please refer to the AGEDS website](#).

Note: The topic of the manuscript is part of qualifying for the program focus, therefore, the student or faculty should write a comment in the comments area, such as: "Creative component will revise Northeast Region Extension Master Gardener online training to include collaboration." The notation can be made at any point in the program.

CERTIFICATE IN EDUCATION AND OUTREACH

The [Education and Outreach in Agriculture and Natural Resources Graduate Certificate](#) is an online certificate for non-formal outreach and education. Students must apply, create a mini Academic Plan, and receive final approval. For further information on certificates, ask [Dr. Nancy Grudens-Schuck](#).

ADDITIONAL ACADEMIC PLAN NOTES

Change from Graduate Academic Advisor to Major Professor

[AGEDS provides a Graduate Academic Advisor upon the Recommendation to Accept](#). This is different from a Major Professor.

Most often, completing the Academic Plan changes the status of the Graduate Academic Advisor to Major Professor. This solidifies the relationship. The student should be aware that this is occurring. However, at this point, the student also has a choice whether to continue with their current Graduate Academic Advisor, or to move to a different advisor.

Students and Advisors should consider the following situations:

- If there is a research assistantship (RA), a student should ask the Graduate Academic Advisor to recommit to being the Major Professor, if they want the same advisor. The Major Professor needs to be clear in their yes/no.
- If there is a research assistantship (RA) and the student no longer wants to work on the RA or have the advisor as a major professor, the student should prepare to resign from the RA. This has implications for funding, tuition, and also level of costs. Before taking action, the student is urged to reach out to the DOGE, [Dr. Nancy Grudens-Schuck](#), or the Department Chair, [Dr. Michael Retallick](#).

There is also a situation for choice for employer or self-funded students:

- If for various reasons of workload or interests, faculty may decline to serve as major professor for a student for whom they are currently the Graduate Academic Advisor. The faculty should inform the student. In this situation, the student is urged to reach out to the DOGE, [Dr. Nancy Grudens-Schuck](#), or the Department Chair, [Dr. Michael Retallick](#).

At all points during the transition, student and faculty should openly communicate back and forth in a professional manner.

When Comments are Required on the Academic Plan

At several points in this Handbook, we have talked about comments on the Academic Plan. The student or advisor may need to write a comment before submitting electronically. Almost all student's Academic Plans utilize the comment box for notes. It helps everyone to understand, and then recall, the decisions that may involve nontraditional courses, courses from other institutions, or substitutions that the committee approved. An email to the DOGE or the Graduate

College is good, but it is not enduring. A Plan may include more than one comment. If needed, ask for help locating the comment box.

What aspects of the Academic Plan require exceptions?

For the doctoral students, special items and exceptions are common. These may include, but are not limited to:

- Allowing transfer courses to apply
- Reasons for substitutions of required and required elective courses
- Independent study and workshop courses
- Renamed courses

Older transfer courses/older ISU courses

Doctoral students and some masters students may have older courses because they teach or work. Expired courses are defined in [Ch. 6.3.4 of the Graduate College Handbook](#). The Graduate College requires a petition form if a student is planning to use any old courses toward their degree. The student will need to [complete and submit a petition](#), but the committee must approve to use the petition first. The entire committee is required to consider and approve each older course and its role. The student should make a brief note about the expired courses that were voted and approved by the committee. The University is the final approver of any expired courses.

5990 AND 6990

For all students, the Academic Plan needs to include AGEDS 5990 or 6990 credits. The minimum is specified in the program of study. But what are they? What are they worth? Are they different?

The Office of the Registrar provides [a page that explains all the different types of courses, such as lectures and labs, and the “990s”](#).

Research (RES) or [Creative Component] A course that requires independent research on the part of the student. It includes only course numbers ending in "990". Hours spent on course per week may vary from week to week.	Average of 3-5 hrs (180-300 minutes) per week of student effort (including contact time with instructor) for the 15-16 weeks of the semester. This equates to total student effort of 2,700-4,800 minutes per credit .
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Example: A student who takes 1 credit of AGEDS 6990 puts in 5 hours per week for the course. If the student enrolls in 3 credits of AGEDS 6990, then the effort rises to 15 hours per week.

It is also true, however, that a graduate student is expected to put in their “own” time above this, to make the research happen.

Also, if there is a research event, such as a focus group, data analysis event, stakeholder meeting that requires travel, school visits to distribute surveys, the research experience requires many more hours per week, and this is considered ordinary.

In many departments, doctoral students take fewer lecture courses, more project-based courses, and a greater proportion of 6990 credits, up to nearly half.

For students on summer assistantship, and/or during the term when anticipating taking the final oral exam, they need to be enrolled in at least one credit of 5990/6990. For preliminary doctoral candidates, especially for international students, there are additional Graduate College courses that may be used.

Major professors are the professor of record for the 5990/6990 courses. A plan of work agreed upon by professor and student is common and likely necessary. As an example: “send and analyze pilot survey; then revise and send final survey.”

The 5990 courses are in the regular part of the Plan. The 6990 are in a separate area on the Plan. The grade is a letter grade, but the value of the letter grade is not counted in the GPA.

Writing a Creative Component, Thesis or Dissertation

The 5990 and 6990 are used for writing, managing the project activity, and manuscripts for the final oral exam. Writing any part of these manuscripts may benefit from, or be required to use, aspects of the Graduate College templates or formatting. Consult thesis and dissertation [formatting assistance web pages](#) and services helpful for creative components.

COMPLETING YOUR PROGRAM

This section will explain a few of the procedures for finishing the creative component, thesis, or dissertation; and graduating. For most of the actions, please access [Graduate College website](#). However, there are some AGEDS items.

FINAL ORAL EXAM

The final oral exam, which is sometimes called a defense, has several moving parts. Student and major professor must make sure that four things happen at once:

- Schedule online for a date, time and locate (or virtual) for the final oral exam. Work closely with your Major Professor and committee members on a date.
- You **must** enroll in at least one graduate credit
 - “When” is tricky. If it is during fall, spring or summer, that is easy. Just enroll in a AGEDS 5990 or 6990 or a course. Students may also enroll in a GRST course. But if you are holding your exam on a date “in between,” you must enroll the term BEFORE.
- [Apply for Program Completion \(Graduation\)](#)
- Upload to Parks Library

- Dissertations: Required
- Thesis: Required
- Creative Component: Required
- Teacher Portfolio: Required (new)

FORMATTING

All students should use the official title page, customized by the student for the program of study, and type of product and copyright statement. Students should either leave time for these details at the end or start early by integrating them into their Academic Plan and final oral exam manuscripts.

The Graduate College checks thesis and dissertations for format issues. The student must take care of nearly all issues ahead of time using the [resource pages](#). Many of our students, especially doctoral students, hire a private editor as well. Sometimes the Major Professor or research supervisor can pay for this. It is recommended that you reach out to an editor sooner rather than later, as their schedules can fill quickly. In all situations, early writing and planning makes this easier. The reward for everyone is clear communication of the topic and a professional quality impression.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

What if a student can't take a course on the Academic Plan?

Occasionally, problems arise. ISU permits the student to revise and resubmit the Academic Plan. However, the rules must still be followed. For example, if the student drops a course required by the major, the course must be retaken, or a substituted course must be approved by the committee and the Graduate College. A student should not assume a substitution is allowed.

What if the Academic Plan has a mistake or needs a change?

A student with an error on their Academic Plan action will need to resubmit the Plan in WorkDay. A common practice is to delete a course, add a new one, and explain the change in the comment box. The updated Plan will then need to be recirculated for approval.

What if a faculty member leaves?

For issues such as professors leaving, or professors who may no longer appear to be active, the DOGE or the Chair of the Department should be notified. These issues have several avenues for solutions. [The Graduate Handbook has ways of addressing these issues](#). A major professor can coach their advisees about their situation, if they are able. If they can't, the Department is ready to support a student.

What if a student or faculty feels they are experiencing a dispute regarding graduate study?

What if resolution is not working at the department level?

[Section 8.5 Mediation of Student Grievances](#) is part of the services of the Graduate College.

What materials should I keep to assist me with my program?

Students in agricultural education masters and doctoral programs of study are strongly advised to retain textbooks, and to download reference lists, syllabus, PowerPoint lectures, and their assignments. Committee members who taught courses will assume students retained books and

key notes. The Learning Management System (such as Canvas) will close shortly after the course is completed and access will be restricted.

- Masters non-thesis students need materials to complete the creative component.
- Masters thesis students need materials to write the proposal and to complete the thesis.
- Doctoral students need materials to complete the Preliminary Exam, the proposal, grants and conference papers, and the dissertation.

Faculty are always willing to provide students with such, but they may be traveling or otherwise engaged in research, teaching or service and timing may not be in your favor.

We acknowledge that there are more issues and resources than spelled out in this handbook, and items we may not have addressed. We hope this small, program-level AGEDS Graduate Program Handbook can help with understanding the Agricultural Education graduate program of study practices and procedures. If not, there are plentiful additional resources, just ask and we will be happy to help you.